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Optimizing the User Interface

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Overview

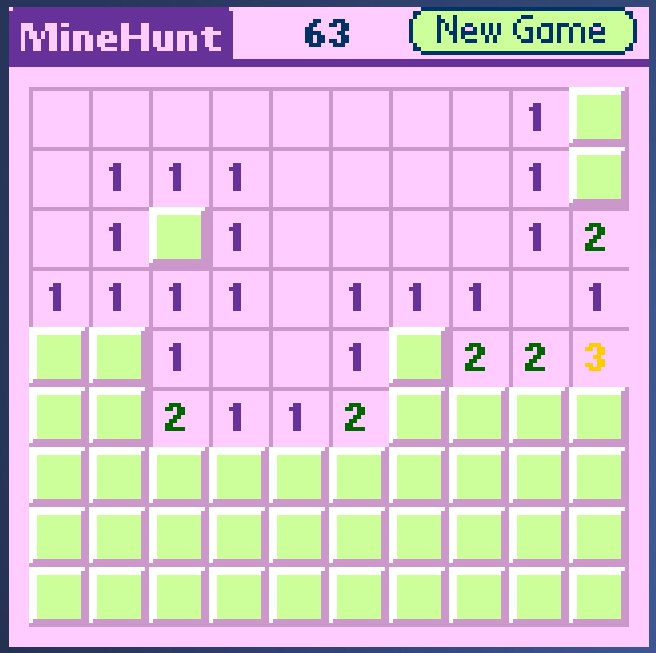
- Color
- UI elements
  - Buttons
  - Checkboxes, push buttons, popup lists
  - Menus, title bars, forms
- Platform challenges
  - Screen
  - Performance

Color

- UI Colors are defined by a table
  - Text fore, text back, button back
- Productivity apps should respect those choices
  - Use system colors to color your app
- Entertaining apps may play with those colors

Color Example

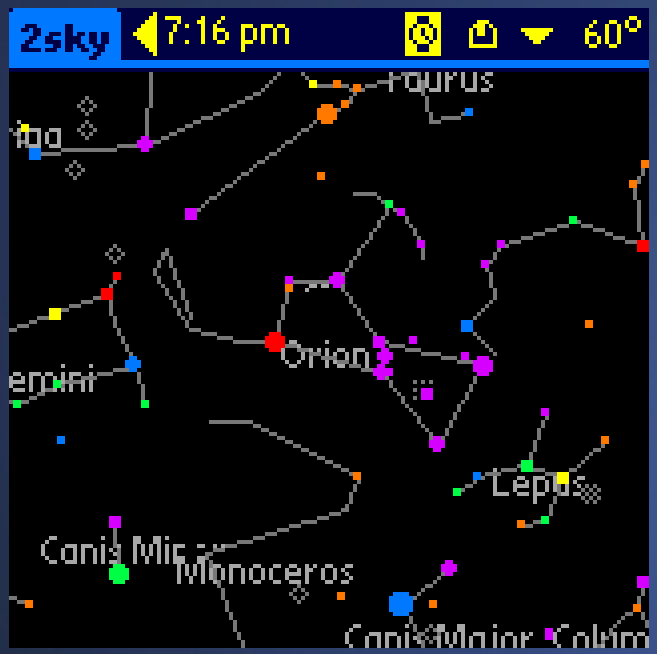
- MineHunt in normal and Classic look





Color Savvy Apps

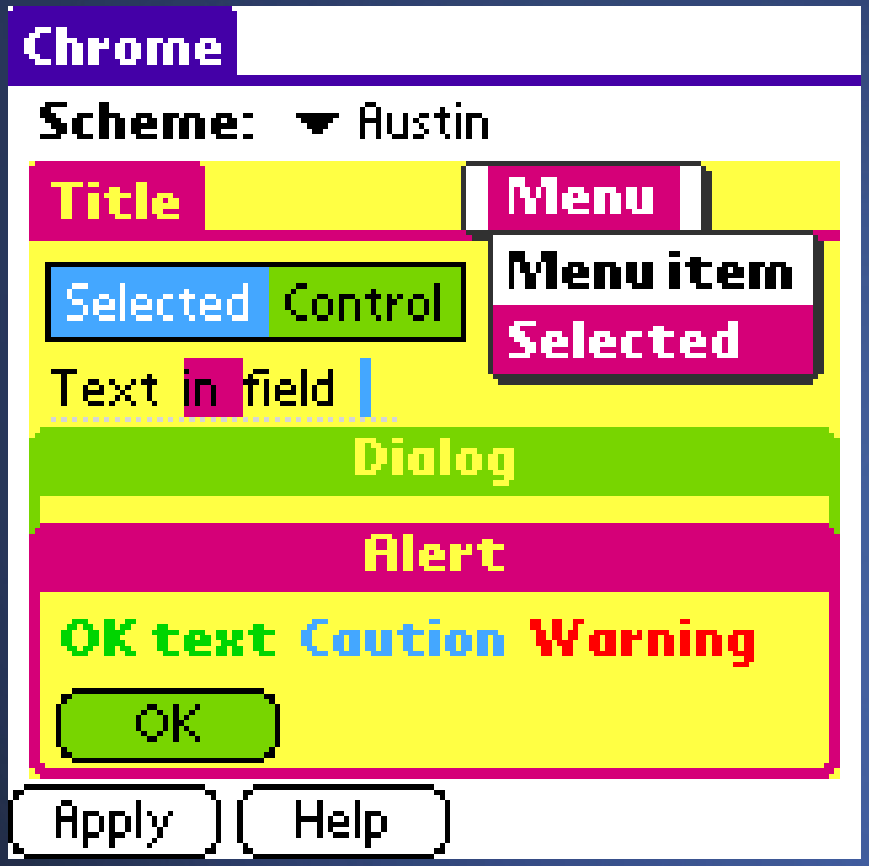
- 2Sky: http://in2space.com/2sky.html





Users Customize Colors

- Chrome: http://www.twinkletwinkle.com/



UI Elements

- Review basic elements
- Review usage
- Guidelines are usually right
  - There are exceptions
  - Consistency is undervalued

Buttons



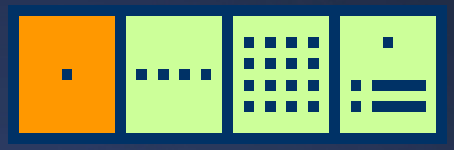
- Bottom only
- 4 pixels apart
- 12 pixels high
- 36 pixels wide when possible
- 4 pixels from dialog edge else flush
- Use for an action
- Add “…” when a dialog will appear

Check Boxes



- Use for two state options
- Rarely exclusive
- Allows for a long description
  - Keep description to the right
  - The text should be selectable

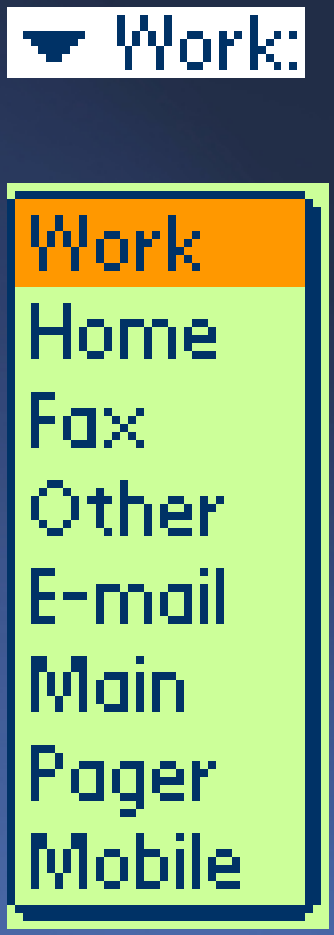
Push Buttons



- Use to quickly select from a small group
- Usually, but not always exclusive
- Very visual

Popup Lists

- Use to select from a range
- Use when seldom changed
- Use when there is limited space
- Two/three items is too few



Selectors



- Use when the contents can be changed

Command Bar

- Across the bottom close to Graffiti® area
- Left justified and prioritized
- Graffiti Shift Indicator and scroll arrows on right

Menus

- For less used features
- The first menu appears by default
- Keep command strokes consistent with PIMs
- Use command strokes only for frequent items
- Use a dialog for preferences
- Menus are not dynamic



Forms



- Use a Title Bar
  - Use for output (away from hand)
  - Use for occasional navigation
  - Provides context
- Dialogs
  - Short as possible
  - Bottom justify and full screen width
  - Don’t deeply nest
  - They don’t support the system’s Find

Miscellaneous Tips

- Use the standard font except for text labels
- Always confirm data deletion with an alert
- Use the large font for important text
- Color bitmaps and icons should use transparency

Palm UI Design

- Use normal UI design techniques
  - User studies
  - Iterative design
- Palm specific design
  - Screen
  - Performance

Guide Users

- Clear license issues
- Clear Instructions
- Default configurations
  - Guided configurations
- Default Doc

Registration

- Goal: prove worth of program
- Always keep the app useful. (Never completely expire)
  - Use a little every day/week/month
  - Only allow easy games
- Beamed apps are sale opportunities

Focus the Design

- Resist Featuritis
  - The challenge is adding without diminishing
- Simplify
- Resist Preferences
  - You can always add them later

Performance

- Perform against the real world
- Common operations must be fast
- Have a smooth, flicker-free appearance

Summary

- Work with color
  - Use the system color table
- Use the UI objects appropriately
  - Watch size and alignment
- Practice good UI design techniques while remembering Palm device constraints


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